at the clock and are surprised to see it is only ten minutes until the first drinks break.

Where did those last fifty minutes go? You can't really remember them, break them down into bite-size chunks for comfortable consumption. They've just happened. You have a drink, take on any messages delivered through the twelfth man, and go again. You're preoccupied by the practicality of batting, the actions that speak louder than any words.

Suddenly, something reminds you, from out of nowhere, to focus on the clock. Only five minutes to lunch? Another hour has disappeared. You can vaguely remember specific shots, mood swings and momentum shifts, but you concentrate on cashing in. There will be other days when you don't have the mojo.

Being out of form is like trying to push a concrete wall away when it is closing in and threatening to crush you, like some sort of fiendish ancient trap. You are out of sync, out of the pattern. Something isn't quite right, and your brain cannot compute. That's when the clock face seizes up. Time passes terribly slowly. It's hard work; half an hour seems like four.

This is going to sound weird, but the art of concentration is in being able to concentrate, and then not concentrate on concentrating. I did so through the routine I've described previously. Play the shot, scratch the line, walk away. Sometimes I'd go down the track and indulge in gentle gardening. Most times I would head in the direction of square leg.

I'd be digging myself in. Look around at the crowd, allow the bowler to have his say. If I'd been beaten, or had an ugly hack, I might wander down and have a chat with the non-striker, whoever it may be. We'd smile, I'd admit 'that was a shit shot' and the situation would be defused. I'd return to the crease, having rationalized what I had done, and let it go.

The sequence probably takes twenty seconds. I'd be consciously calm by the time the bowler turned from his mark to run in. We go again, and again, and again. When you are in form, it is metronomic. When you are out of form, you are fighting yourself. You start to worry about your foot position, how you've bent your knee, all the stuff you shouldn't be thinking about. If you can't get rid of that, you're in a skid that's extremely difficult to correct.

Maintaining concentration during the entirety of an interval is impossible. If I was set at lunch, I'd take my pads off, have a bite to eat and have a variety of conversations, some cricket-related, others